SECTION 15

As you may have discussed above, children do not come to class to stay quiet. Neither should it be your intention to keep them that way. You should try to take advantage of their natural energy and channel it into learning. To do this, you will need to plan for quiet moments and for periods of activity and spontaneity. In all cases, organization is a basic element. When a class is well organized, it is easier for the children to concentrate and to learn. It is worthwhile to consider at least the following three points in this connection:

1. Each class period should begin in a clear and consistent way and end in an orderly way as well.

2. A routine needs to be established. Thus, little by little, the children come to know which activity follows which and what is expected of them.

3. The time dedicated to each activity should be flexible and should depend on the enthusiasm and energy of the children.

As noted in the description in the preceding section, the activities the children will carry out in every class period are as follows:

a. Reciting and memorizing prayers

b. Singing songs

c. Learning and memorizing quotations from the Bahá'í Writings

d. Listening to stories

e. Playing games

f. Coloring in drawings

g. Reciting closing prayers

These activities naturally tend to differ in the level of energy and degree of movement they require; some will be very active and others more tranquil.

Which of these seven activities involve the most movement? _____

_____

_____

_____

Which are quieter activities? _____

_____

_____

_____

There are certain demands that maintaining an orderly atmosphere places on the teacher. Which of the following contribute to the desired atmosphere and which hamper it? Mark them with a "C" or an "H" accordingly.

____ Keeping the space where the class is held clean and organized

____ Remaining calm and patient, no matter the circumstances

____ Losing one's patience when the children do not listen to directions

____ Preparing the materials for each activity in advance

____ Looking everywhere for the supplies for a given activity while the children wait

____ Explaining clearly what the children are meant to do for each activity

____ Having other activities ready for children who finish their tasks early in order to keep them engaged

____ Helping children transition from one activity to another in an orderly manner

____ Reading the story to the children from the book

____ Learning the story so well that it can be told to the children with enthusiasm and ease

SECTION 16

In striving to create an atmosphere of discipline and order in the class, you will need to establish certain standards of conduct. The first few weeks will be particularly important in this respect. Whatever expectations are set during this initial period are likely to be maintained throughout the year. In the beginning, the teacher should choose several standards of behavior and explain them, not more than three or four at a time, in a simple language to the children. Very general standards like "We should behave ourselves" do not help them much, but others like "We take turns when speaking" are easy to understand. Discuss with the members of your group the standards set in the statements below and add a few more to the list.

a. We help each other when we play a game.

b. We remain united and do not fight.

c. We welcome new friends to our class.

d. We listen to each other and to our teacher when they speak.

e. We speak to one another with a kindly tongue.

f. We wait our turn to speak.

g. We share our crayons with each other.

h. We try to finish our tasks.

i. _____

j. _____

k. _____

l. _____

Expectations for behavior, when composed as simple sentences such as these, can be discussed with the children, and the statements recited with them regularly. In this way, the statements can be internalized as standards to which the children aspire and will not be perceived as rules rigidly imposed. When they have become familiar with a given set of expectations, the teacher can gradually introduce others, remembering to avoid adding many all at once. Should a particular difficulty arise during a class, the children can be assisted in creating some simple sentences that address it. In such instances, the teacher should be firm and consistent, yet at the same time friendly and full of tenderness.

SECTION 17

In Section 8 we briefly examined the significance of the various elements of the Grade 1 lessons and discussed how they each strive to contribute to a praiseworthy character. In this and the next seven sections we will consider some of the approaches you can take in engaging children in the activities suggested, beginning with memorization.

The memorization of prayers and quotations from the Writings is central to the lessons you will be teaching, and in every class period you will be helping your students in their efforts to recite prayers from memory and to learn one new quotation by heart. Before we discuss how you can go about engaging them in this activity, a few words should be said about a common misconception that ought best to be set aside in trying to assist youngsters in memorizing the Sacred Word.

You may have heard, or may hear as you begin teaching, comments such as “children should not repeat things”, “they should learn to express their own ideas”, “they should not parrot facts and information”. In fact, so pervasive is the criticism of so-called rote-learning that these ideas are becoming more and more widespread in all parts of the world. It is true that one could memorize an equation in mathematics, the definition of a law in physics, or a piece of prose in literature with little or no understanding of it. But the question you should ask yourself is this: Why should memorization of a profound statement and comprehension of its meaning be placed in opposition to one another? Memory is as much a power of the human mind as are the powers of comprehension, thought, and imagination. They all complement and reinforce each other. We can only imagine how much the memorization of the Word of God, with its endless potentialities to recreate the human heart and mind, will enhance intelligence and understanding in children. Later, as they go through different stages of growth, they will gain fresh insights from the passages they have committed to memory, and all throughout their lives they will be able to draw on the creative, regenerative and transformative powers of the Word of God.

Discuss with the other members of your group why it is important for teachers to be convinced that memorization of the Word of God helps to firmly plant in the minds and hearts of children seeds of spiritual knowledge, seeds that will grow over time to bear luscious fruits.

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

SECTION 18

With the above reflection in mind, let us give thought to how you will go about helping your students to memorize passages from the Writings, taking the quotation in Lesson 1 as an example. To begin, you will want to assist them in gaining some initial insights into the significance of the spiritual quality on which the lesson focuses. For this purpose, a short introductory statement is provided for you to draw upon. You are then encouraged to help them acquire a first basic understanding of the meaning of the quotation by selecting the difficult words it contains and using them in situations with which the children can easily identify. Consider this approach as described in Lesson 1, which addresses the quality of purity.

Our hearts are like mirrors. We should always keep them clean. Holding a grudge towards someone, feeling jealous of someone, and being unkind to anyone for whatever reason—these are like dust that cover the mirror of our hearts. When our hearts are pure, they reflect the light of God and His attributes—attributes such as kindness, love, and generosity—and we become a cause of happiness to others. To help keep our hearts pure, let us memorize this quotation of Bahá'u'lláh:

"O Son of Spirit! My first counsel is this: Possess a pure, kindly and radiant heart . . ."

Counsel

1. One day Gerard and Mary were coloring some drawings. Gerard needed the yellow crayon, but Mary did not want to give it to him. The teacher told Mary that she should share. The teacher gave Mary good counsel.

2. Patricia has to decide whether to spend her money on candy or on a storybook. Her parents advise her to buy the storybook. Her parents give Patricia good counsel.

Possess

1. Tinaye likes to read prayers before going to sleep. She has a small prayer book to read from. Tinaye possesses a small prayer book.

2. We grow many delicious vegetables in our garden. We possess a good plot of land that gives us many fresh vegetables.

Pure heart

1. Cathy became angry and said unkind words to Agot. Agot was sad but quickly forgave Cathy. Agot possesses a pure heart.

2. Gustavo likes to share his cookies with all the children, even with Jorge, who does not share anything with others. Gustavo possesses a pure heart.

Kindly heart

1. When her parents invite friends to their home, Ming Ling happily serves them food. Ming Ling possesses a kindly heart.

2. Mr. Robertson is very old. Jimmy helps him carry his fruit harvest to the market. Jimmy possesses a kindly heart.

Radiant heart

1. When I feel sad, my mother always cheers me up and makes me happy. My mother possesses a radiant heart.

2. Obuya became ill and had to spend all his time in bed. He said many prayers, did not become sad, and continued to show forth happiness. Obuya possesses a radiant heart.

Of course, you will not simply read the introductory statement and explanatory sentences from the book, and so you will need to prepare well in advance in order to present them in a natural way.

As for the prayers the children memorize, it is suggested that you take a similar approach, but it will be left for you to decide which words or phrases may require explanation. You will want to exercise some care in this respect. There are times when it may be sufficient to allow the youngsters to glean the meaning of words gradually from the prayers themselves. Look, for example, at the prayer below that the children begin to learn in Lesson 1. They will readily recognize that both a "pure heart" and a "pearl" are something precious. But, in order to understand that, ultimately, a pure heart is given to us by God, they will probably need to learn what the word "bestow" means. What sentences would you devise for this purpose?

"He is God! O God, my God! Bestow upon me a pure heart, like unto a pearl."[37]

_____

_____

_____

_____

SECTION 19

Now let us consider one approach you can take in helping your students to memorize prayers and quotations. What you can do is divide the passage into smaller parts, which can then be learned one at a time. After the first part has been committed to memory, the second can be added to it and so on, until the entire quotation or prayer has been memorized. You can ask the children to repeat the parts after you, sometimes individually and other times as a group.

For example, to teach your students the quotation in Lesson 1, you would begin with the phrase "O Son of Spirit!" and have them repeat it. Then you would combine "O Son of Spirit!" with "My first counsel is this" and ask them to repeat the two phrases together. Finally you would add the words "Possess a pure, kindly and radiant heart". Once the group has learned the quotation in this way, a few of the children could be helped to recite it from memory. Of course, you would need to make sure this exercise is done in a sprightly manner, so the children remain attentive and a joyful atmosphere is maintained. Further, as their capacity gradually increases, they may be able to memorize longer segments in prayers and entire quotations all at once.

As you carry out this portion of the class, certain situations may present themselves that are difficult to anticipate, and you will have to learn how to address these through firsthand experience. Still, there are some situations that you would do well to consider as part of your preparations. Discuss the following questions with the other members of your group:

- If there are many children in your class, how will you go about helping them to memorize the quotation?
- What will you do if some of the children memorize faster than the rest?
- What will you do if one or more children have difficulty memorizing?
- How will you ensure that, even when a child is unable to memorize a quotation in its entirety during class, he or she still feels a sense of accomplishment?

SECTION 20

Children love to sing, and this activity, which precedes the memorization of quotations, is one of the most joyful. The key to success is practice. You yourself should sing the songs

with someone who knows them, paying special attention to the rhythm and the melody. If you can listen to recordings of the songs, you will learn them even faster. With the children, you will also have to sing the songs over and over until they have learned them well. The words of the songs can be memorized in much the same way as those of the quotations, only this time the words are repeated along with the melody. You may find, depending on the capacity of your students, that some of the songs are too difficult for them to sing. In such cases, it may be possible for you to sing the verses and for your students to join you in singing the chorus.

SECTION 21

The next activity we will consider is storytelling. As mentioned earlier, most of the stories in the first grade are drawn from the life of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá. These stories serve a very special purpose. They help children see how the spiritual qualities they are trying to acquire were completely manifested in the perfect Exemplar throughout His days on this earthly plane. The reverence shown by a teacher when narrating these accounts stirs heavenly emotions in their tender hearts and awakens their spiritual susceptibilities.

Though the stories you will tell the children about ‘Abdu’l-Bahá are short, the spiritual insights they offer are profound. You will therefore want to take your students beyond the events described to help them catch glimpses into spiritual reality. Let us examine the story from Lesson 1 in this light.

‘Abdu’l-Bahá could always tell what was in a person’s heart, and He greatly loved people whose hearts were pure and radiant. There was a lady who had the honor of being the guest of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá at dinner. As she sat listening to His words of wisdom, she looked at a glass of water in front of her and thought, “Oh! If only ‘Abdu’l-Bahá would take my heart and empty it of every earthly desire and then refill it with Divine love and understanding, just as you would do with this glass of water.”

This thought passed through her mind quickly, and she did not say anything about it, but soon something happened that made her realize ‘Abdu’l-Bahá had known what she was thinking. While He was in the middle of His talk, He paused to call over an attendant and said a few words to him softly. The attendant quietly came to the lady’s place at the table, took her glass, emptied it, and put it back in front of her.

A little later, ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, while continuing to talk, picked up a pitcher of water from the table, and in a most natural way, slowly refilled the lady’s empty glass. No one noticed what had happened, but the lady knew that ‘Abdu’l-Bahá was answering her heart’s desire. She was filled with joy. Now she knew that hearts and minds were like open books to ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, Who read them with great love and kindliness.

Clearly purity is the spiritual quality on which the story—and, indeed, the entire lesson—is focused. The following questions will help you think about how your narration will deepen the students' understanding of this quality and what it means to strive for it.

1. It will be important for the children to recognize that 'Abdu'l-Bahá's guest was longing to acquire purity of heart. What is the connection in the story between this longing and the glass of water in front of the guest?

2. To attain unto purity, we must, just as a glass is emptied and refilled, rid ourselves of unworthy thoughts and feelings, that God may illumine our hearts with qualities such as love, generosity, and kindness. We know, of course, that nothing can be hidden from the sight of God. How does this understanding help us in our efforts to strive for purity?

After discussing these questions with the other members of your group, write down some of your thoughts here.

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

There are a few stories in this grade that, although not related to the life of 'Abdu'l-Bahá, illustrate the significance of spiritual qualities. In them, children are able to see the reward for showing forth these qualities and the consequences of neglecting them. For example, the story in Lesson 4 of the shepherd who cries wolf, well known in many cultures, demonstrates the consequences of lying and, in this way, provides insights into the quality of truthfulness. Children can benefit greatly from the messages conveyed in these stories, which will prove valuable to them in the formation of their characters.

SECTION 22

Storytelling is an art. To tell a story effectively, one must be well acquainted with it. In this section, we will study in greater detail the story from Lesson 1 to see how a teacher should go about narrating it to children.

We have established that the central theme of the story is the spiritual quality of purity of heart, which is explored through the example of the glass. The first question you need to ask yourself then is, What parts of the story are directly related to this main theme? That 'Abdu'l-Bahá's words of wisdom cause the lady to think of how much she wants to purify her heart of earthly desire, like the glass in front of her, is one essential part. The instructions given by 'Abdu'l-Bahá to the attendant to discard the water in the glass, which

‘Abdu’l-Bahá later refills, is another. What would it be like if you did not mention, for example, that ‘Abdu’l-Bahá asked the attendant to empty the lady’s glass?

Now, even though we have identified the essential parts of the story, its other details cannot be forgotten. Would it be a story if you simply said that a guest of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, while sitting at dinner, wished that her heart could be purified in the same way one would empty a glass? There are always details in a story which give it more feeling and make it engaging. What are these?

- The thought of the empty glass occurs to the guest over a meal, while listening to ‘Abdu’l-Bahá share His wisdom, but she never voices her thought out loud.

- Though speaking to those gathered at the dinner, ‘Abdu’l-Bahá pauses to address the woman’s unvoiced thought.

- No one else notices what has happened.

- The guest feels immense joy in knowing that ‘Abdul-Bahá recognizes her heart’s desire.

It should be noted here that every teacher must take care not to embellish the stories in Grade 1 with additional details and other elements, which can divert the children’s attention from the spiritual truths that the stories are meant to convey.

Throughout your narration, then, you will want to keep in mind that the purpose of telling a story is to teach something important to the children. When you recount it with joy and feeling, they will understand it better. Children are not going to be interested in a story told monotonously. You must learn to communicate emotions such as happiness, sorrow, disappointment, fear, and courage through your voice, facial expressions, and gestures. The tone and volume of your voice should change according to the story’s development, and your gestures, though simple, should correspond with each part. You need to think, too, about the rhythm and pace of your narration. If you talk too slowly, the children will become bored, and if you talk too quickly, they will not be able to follow the story. Above all, you should remember that you are not playacting and that your feelings must be sincere. Youngsters can easily detect a lack of sincerity. What is desired is to connect with the hearts of the children and to carry on the longstanding tradition of storytelling through which, for millennia now, the store of wisdom acquired by humanity has been passed from one generation to the next.

SECTION 23

Now let us consider the two activities that follow storytelling—playing games and coloring. In this section we will discuss how to approach the period dedicated to games, and coloring will be addressed in the next.

As mentioned earlier, the games in Grade 1 are cooperative in nature. Many people believe that, for games to be challenging, children need to compete with one another. What we should realize is that, when children are put in situations in which they have to compete, certain undesirable attitudes and habits are cultivated that last well beyond the duration of the game. Further, there is a notion that excellence can only be achieved through competition.

You need to examine closely the veracity of this idea. Is it really true that we cannot achieve excellence through cooperation? In competition, some win while others lose; in cooperation everyone feels a sense of accomplishment.

Games in the first grade seek to enhance in children the skills of listening to and following instructions. They will also come to see that each game establishes a common goal for the whole class and that, in coordinating their efforts, every one of them has a role to play in achieving it. Above all, it is expected that they will increase the degree of care they show towards one another, learn perseverance, and strengthen the bonds of friendship that connect them. You should remember, then, that they need not play a game perfectly to feel a sense of success. Look, for instance, at the game suggested in Lesson 1. How does it contribute to the desired aims?

> For the next activity, place a car tire on the ground and then ask the children to see how many of them can stand in it at the same time. If a tire is not available, you could place a mat or towel, or some similar object, on the ground instead. Whatever object you choose, it should be small enough to make the game a challenge for the number of children in the class.

The way a teacher introduces a game affects how children play it. Its objective should be clearly explained. Further, when giving instructions to the children, a teacher will often have to demonstrate how to play it and practice it with them.

SECTION 24

Artistic activities are important to the development of children's creativity and mental skills, and from an early age they should be given the opportunity to exercise their imagination through freestyle drawing and other forms of artistic expression. However, in many parts of the world, children will have had little chance to draw prior to the age of five or six, much less have had access to crayons. For them, coloring in the pictures provided with the lessons in the first grade is one of the most exciting periods of the class, and it creates in them the necessary confidence to move on to more complex artistic activities in the subsequent grades. It is also a means to develop their dexterity and a sense of discipline. How are the following abilities, skills and attitudes enhanced in children through coloring?

- Appreciating order and beauty
- Paying attention to detail
- Focusing on the task at hand
- Sharing resources with others
- Respecting others

In addition to fostering certain skills and attitudes, the period of the class dedicated to coloring offers the teacher yet another opportunity to discuss with his or her students the

qualities treated in the lessons in Grade 1. By asking the class questions about the depictions in the drawings, teachers can give children a chance to articulate ideas and make connections in their minds as they talk about what is happening in the picture. Look at the coloring sheet for the first lesson and explore with your group how you would introduce it to the children. Write down your thoughts below.

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

A teacher must prepare adequately for this activity. Children invariably show a great desire to color; yet, this portion of the class can become chaotic if not properly organized. A place for the children to color should be identified, and copies of the drawing for each lesson prepared beforehand. Particularly in the first few lessons, the teacher may need to set a standard for how children should conduct themselves with the crayons and establish with them a sense of discipline and cooperation. Initially, every child could be asked to choose one crayon from the box held by the teacher. When they want to change colors, they can hand in the crayon and exchange it for another. After several classes, when they have become accustomed to having only one color at a time, the box of crayons can be left in a central place.

Now, look at the situations below. Which situation in each pair will contribute to the effectiveness of this activity?

____ The teacher allows a child to color outside the lines, so long as he or she is trying to color well.

____ All the children are told to color strictly within the lines.

____ While the children are coloring, the teacher walks among them, giving them help and encouragement.

____ While the children are coloring, the teacher sits and does some of his or her own work.

____ During the time allotted for coloring, the children concentrate on the task at hand.

____ During the time allotted for coloring, the children distract each other.

____ While they are coloring, the children remain absolutely silent.

____ While they are coloring, the children joyfully interact and encourage one another.

SECTION 25

Many teachers find it useful to keep a notebook where some basic information on the group of youngsters they teach can be maintained. Two tables are helpful in this regard, one

with the names and ages of the students to record their attendance in the classes and another to keep track of their progress in memorizing the quotations. This latter table can have, for example, the names of the children in the left column and the numbers of the lessons in the row across the top. The teacher can then mark in the appropriate cells which children have memorized which quotations.

The notebook can also have a section dedicated to the lessons themselves, where teachers can record their analysis of each lesson, their thoughts on how to teach it, and, later, their reflections on how the sessions with the children unfolded.

In another section, the teacher can make note of each child's progress, as well as any particular anecdotes that could be shared with his or her parents. Some teachers also find it helpful to include in this section the names of the child's parents and siblings and short summaries of topics addressed during visits to their home.

SECTION 26

As a teacher of a children's class, you will need to establish a close and loving relationship with the parents of each child, meeting with them regularly to discuss the growth and development of their son or daughter and seeking their support. You may have already visited families of some of the children who attend classes in your community after having completed your study of Book 2. To refresh your memory, you may wish to refer to Section 15 in the third unit of that book. In that section we see how Maribel, a teacher of children's classes, gathers her thoughts together about what she will say to Emma's mother on her second visit to their home. She decides to start by telling her of the joy that Emma's presence in the class brings to her heart and by mentioning the wonderful qualities she has discovered in her daughter. How significant is it for parents to see the joy and enthusiasm with which a teacher serves the children of the community? What are some other attributes that will attract the hearts of parents and create bonds of trust with them?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Why is it important for a teacher to bring to the attention of parents the spiritual qualities that he or she notices their child is developing?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Maribel also decides to share with Emma's mother the quotation you studied in Section 3 of this unit and to explore with her its implications for the education of children. In the many conversations in which you engage with parents, you will have the opportunity to explain the educational ideas that have given shape to the children's class program. Below are some of the concepts that you have have examined in this unit. What will you say to parents about each one in the context of the spiritual education of their children? Are there any passages from the Writings related to one or another concept that you will share in your conversations with parents?

The development of a praiseworthy character: _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

The acquisition of spiritual qualities: _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

The effect of prayer on the hearts of children: _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

The importance of memorization of the Word of God: _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

The edifying influence on children of stories from the life of 'Abdu'l-Bahá: ____

_____

_____

_____

_____

The love of God and the fear of God: _____

_____

Discipline and freedom: _____

Maribel decides to pause during her presentation of ideas and invite Emma's mother to express her thoughts. It is expected that a profound conversation will develop over time between teachers and parents of children. Why is it important that, from their very first visit to parents, teachers elicit from them comments, thoughts, and ideas on the themes being considered?

In addition to discussing with parents the general concept of spiritual qualities, you should take advantage of opportunities that present themselves throughout the year to converse with them about the particular qualities the lessons strive to cultivate in their daughters and sons. Bearing in mind the insights you have gained into the quality of purity of heart, addressed in Lesson 1, explore with the members of your study group how you might approach such a conversation.

Maribel is aware that there needs to be mutual understanding and support between herself and the mother of Emma, if her daughter is to receive the full benefit of the classes she is attending. The prayers and quotations learned in class, for example, can be recited at home with the help of parents. In this way, children are better able to internalize the Word of God, which will penetrate their hearts and souls and give shape to their characters. Discuss with the members of your group in what ways parents can reinforce and support the efforts of teachers.

The desired attributes of heart and mind can only be nurtured in children through proper education over a long period of time. It is clear by now that what should be emphasized in your regular meetings with parents is the progress made by their children, no matter how

small. As your conversation advances, you can explore with parents how to build on these achievements. When such a positive mode of communication has been established, the teacher will then be able to share with parents, with a great deal of care, any difficulties he or she has observed in their children. The aim should be to find a means of collaboration that will help a child overcome his or her difficulties. Discuss with your group the importance of creating such a constructive mode of communication with parents.

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

SECTION 27

As mentioned at the beginning of the unit, not everyone who participates in this course will undertake to establish a children's class. Of those who do, some may choose to hold a class only for a time before moving on to another sphere of service. Still others will dedicate themselves to this area of endeavor, sustaining over a long period classes that nurture children in the love of God. Yet, irrespective of the path participants take, all will have occasion to interact with the younger members of their community, whether in calling upon neighbors, in attending meetings and gatherings, or as siblings and parents. Whatever the circumstances, the concepts and ideas explored in this unit will offer participants insight into the responsibility of their community to care for, as the Universal House of Justice tells us, its "most precious treasure". May all of us, as we look with expectant eyes towards humanity's bright future, derive inspiration and sustenance from the following passages:

"We prescribe unto all men that which will lead to the exaltation of the Word of God amongst His servants, and likewise, to the advancement of the world of being and the uplift of souls. To this end, the greatest means is education of the child."[38]

"The education and training of children is among the most meritorious acts of humankind and draweth down the grace and favor of the All-Merciful, for education is the indispensable foundation of all human excellence and alloweth man to work his way to the heights of abiding glory. If a child be trained from his infancy, he will, through the loving care of the Holy Gardener, drink in the crystal waters of the spirit and of knowledge, like a young tree amid the rilling brooks. And certainly he will gather to himself the bright rays of the Sun of Truth, and through its light and heat will grow ever fresh and fair in the garden of life. . . .

"If, in this momentous task, a mighty effort be exerted, the world of humanity will shine out with other adornings, and shed the fairest light. Then will this darksome place grow luminous, and this abode of earth turn into Heaven."[39]

REFERENCES

1. From a message dated 21 April 2000, published in *Messages from the Universal House of Justice, 1986–2001: The Fourth Epoch of the Formative Age* (Wilmette: Bahá'í Publishing Trust, 2010), no. 331.26, p. 727.

2. Bahá'u'lláh, in "A Compilation on Bahá'í Education", compiled by the Research Department of the Universal House of Justice, published in *The Compilation of Compilations* (Maryborough: Bahá'í Publications Australia, 1991), vol. 1, no. 576, p. 251.

3. *Selections from the Writings of 'Abdu'l-Bahá* (Wilmette: Bahá'í Publishing, 2010, 2015 printing), no. 106.1, p. 187.

4. 'Abdu'l-Bahá, in "A Compilation on Bahá'í Education", published in *The Compilation of Compilations*, vol. 1, no. 614, pp. 273–74.

5. *Gleanings from the Writings of Bahá'u'lláh* (Wilmette: Bahá'í Publishing Trust, 1983, 2017 printing), CXXII, par. 1, p. 294.

6. *Selections from the Writings of 'Abdu'l-Bahá*, no. 108.1, p. 188.

7. Ibid., no. 110.2, p. 190.

8. Ibid., no. 100.2, p. 179.

9. Ibid., no. 99.1, pp. 178–79.

10. Ibid., no. 103.5, p. 183.

11. Ibid., no. 122.1, pp. 198–99.

12. Words of 'Abdu'l-Bahá, cited in *Star of the West*, vol. 8, no. 4 (17 May 1917), p. 41.

13. *Gleanings from the Writings of Bahá'u'lláh*, CXXXVI, par. 2, p. 334; also in *Bahá'í Prayers: A Selection of Prayers Revealed by Bahá'u'lláh, the Báb, and 'Abdu'l-Bahá* (Wilmette: Bahá'í Publishing Trust, 2002, 2017 printing), p. iii.

14. From a talk given on 5 August 1912, published in *The Promulgation of Universal Peace: Talks Delivered by 'Abdu'l-Bahá during His Visit to the United States and Canada in 1912* (Wilmette: Bahá'í Publishing, 2012), par. 6, p. 345.

15. 'Abdu'l-Bahá, in *Prayer and Devotional Life: A Compilation of Extracts from the Writings of Bahá'u'lláh, the Báb, and 'Abdu'l-Bahá and the Letters of Shoghi Effendi and the Universal House of Justice*, compiled by the Research Department of the Universal House of Justice (Wilmette: Bahá'í Publishing, 2019), no. 24, p. 7.

16. *Gleanings from the Writings of Bahá'u'lláh*, XLIII, par. 9, p. 109.

17. From a talk given by 'Abdu'l-Bahá on 24 April 1912, published in *The Promulgation of Universal Peace*, par. 1, p. 71.

18. Bahá'u'lláh, *The Hidden Words* (Wilmette: Bahá'í Publishing Trust, 2003, 2012 printing), Arabic no. 3, p. 4.

19. Ibid., Arabic no. 12, p. 6.

20. Ibid., Arabic no. 11, p. 6.

21. *Gleanings from the Writings of Bahá'u'lláh*, CXXVIII, par. 6, p. 313.

22. *The Call of the Divine Beloved: Selected Mystical Works of Bahá'u'lláh* (Haifa: Bahá'í World Centre, 2018), no. 2.43, p. 31.

23. *The Hidden Words*, Arabic no. 59, p. 17.

24. From a talk given by 'Abdu'l-Bahá on 26 May 1912, published in *The Promulgation of Universal Peace*, par. 1, p. 204.

25. *Selections from the Writings of 'Abdu'l-Bahá*, no. 129.2, p. 204.

26. *Gleanings from the Writings of Bahá'u'lláh*, CLV, par. 4, pp. 376–77.

27. Ibid., CLIII, par. 5, p. 369.

28. *The Hidden Words*, Arabic no. 9, p. 5.

29. From a talk given by 'Abdu'l-Bahá on 24 April 1912, published in *The Promulgation of Universal Peace*, par. 4, p. 73.

30. Bahá'u'lláh, *Epistle to the Son of the Wolf* (Wilmette: Bahá'í Publishing Trust, 1988, 2016 printing), p. 27.

31. *Tablets of Bahá'u'lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas* (Wilmette: Bahá'í Publishing Trust, 1988, 2005 printing), no. 8.53, p. 126.

32. 'Abdu'l-Bahá, *The Secret of Divine Civilization* (Wilmette: Bahá'í Publishing, 2007, 2016 printing), par. 74, p. 53.

33. *Selections from the Writings of 'Abdu'l-Bahá*, no. 111.1, p. 191.

34. Ibid., no. 95.2, pp. 176–77.

35. Ibid., no. 111.4, pp. 191–92.

36. Ibid., no. 124.1, p. 200.

37. 'Abdu'l-Bahá, in *Bahá'í Prayers*, p. 29.

38. From a Tablet revealed by Bahá'u'lláh, in *Social Action: A Compilation Prepared by the Research Department of the Universal House of Justice* (Wilmette: Bahá'í Publishing Trust, 2020), no. 178, p. 107.

39. *Selections from the Writings of 'Abdu'l-Bahá*, no. 103.1–3, p. 182.



Lessons for Children's Classes Grade 1

Purpose

To develop the capacity to teach classes for children aged five or six
that, focused on the refinement of character, consist of
the memorization of prayers and quotations
and songs, stories, games, and coloring

SECTION 1

In the last unit you thought about the nature of your teaching effort in the first grade and examined the various elements that make up a lesson. This second unit contains the twenty-four lessons themselves, which, as you know, are structured around the development of spiritual qualities. In these preliminary sections, you will be given an opportunity to familiarize yourself with the content of the lessons and practice conducting them. What we will do is take four lessons at a time and reflect on the spiritual qualities addressed in each one. You will then be encouraged to go through the lessons in detail with your fellow participants, taking turns carrying out the different activities, before you move on to the next four lessons.

SECTION 2

Every class period in Grade 1 should begin with an opening prayer recited by the teacher. As an assistance, one new prayer will be suggested for you to say every four lessons, for a total of six prayers altogether. If you are able to commit these prayers to memory, it will greatly encourage the children in their own memorization efforts. For Lessons 1 to 4, the following prayer is suggested:

> **"O God! Educate these children. These children are the plants of Thine orchard, the flowers of Thy meadow, the roses of Thy garden. Let Thy rain fall upon them; let the Sun of Reality shine upon them with Thy love. Let Thy breeze refresh them in order that they may be trained, grow and develop, and appear in the utmost beauty. Thou art the Giver. Thou art the Compassionate."[1]**

After offering the above prayer, you will encourage a few children to say one they know by heart. Not all the youngsters may be able to contribute to this portion of the class at the start. Gradually, however, more and more will be able to do so, as they commit to memory the prayers they learn in this grade. From your study of the previous unit, you are already familiar with the one below, on which they will focus their efforts in these first few lessons.

> **"He is God! O God, my God! Bestow upon me a pure heart, like unto a pearl."[2]**

The period dedicated to opening prayers is most crucial; it will create an atmosphere of devotion to God, an atmosphere which is conducive to learning. 'Abdu'l-Bahá tells us that gathering children together and teaching them prayers "bringeth joy" to their hearts. Conversation with God "engenders the susceptibilities of the higher intelligence".

Children should be assisted in developing a profound sense of reverence towards God and in conducting themselves accordingly when praying. They may need to be helped to center their hearts and minds on the Sacred Word, whether they are praying themselves or listening to a prayer being recited by another child. The teacher can ask the children how they can show forth reverence—for example, how they should sit, what they should do with their hands so they do not become a distraction, and what they should do with their eyes if they find them wandering. The teacher can also have them demonstrate how they prepare themselves for prayer. You will want to remember that it is better for only three or four children to say prayers in a spiritual atmosphere than for every single child to recite one while there is noise and movement. It would be advisable, then, for you to select in advance the children

who will offer prayers at the beginning of each class period. You will want to make sure that every child is given the opportunity to recite a prayer at least once every three or four classes.

Throughout the year, it will be important for you to speak with your students from time to time about the nature of prayer and why we pray. Describe in the space below what you might say to them during the first few weeks.

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

SECTION 3

Now read through the first four lessons carefully, one by one, with the other members of your group. You should pay particular attention to the introductory comments and the quotations the students will commit to memory. Of course, you know that the first lesson focuses on the theme of purity. Write down the spiritual quality around which each of the next three lessons revolves.

Lesson 1: Purity

Lesson 2: _____

Lesson 3: _____

Lesson 4: _____

In preparing to teach these lessons, you should spend some time reflecting on the quality addressed in each one, as you have already done on purity of heart in the first unit. Below are a few quotations from the Writings related to the other three qualities. It is suggested that you read each set several times with your group and reflect together on the passages, keeping in mind the quotation your students will memorize. Afterwards, write down some of your thoughts on the significance of the quality in the life of the individual, in general, and to your efforts as a teacher, in particular. Remember that these quotations are not intended for the youngsters in your class but for your own reflection.

Regarding justice, we read:

"The light of men is Justice. Quench it not with the contrary winds of oppression and tyranny. The purpose of justice is the appearance of unity among men."[3]

"No radiance can compare with that of justice. The organization of the world and the tranquility of mankind depend upon it."[4]

"That which traineth the world is Justice, for it is upheld by two pillars, reward and punishment. These two pillars are the sources of life to the world."[5]

"O Son of Spirit! The best beloved of all things in My sight is Justice; turn not away therefrom if thou desirest Me, and neglect it not that I may confide in thee. By its aid thou shalt see with thine own eyes and not through the eyes of others, and shalt know of thine own knowledge and not through the knowledge of thy neighbor. Ponder this in thy heart; how it behooveth thee to be. Verily justice is My gift to thee and the sign of My loving-kindness. Set it then before thine eyes."[6]

About the quality of love, the Writings tell us:

"The essence of love is for man to turn his heart to the Beloved One, and sever himself from all else but Him, and desire naught save that which is the desire of his Lord."[7]

"In this day, to serve the Cause of God is to engender love and fellowship amongst His friends."[8]

"The purpose of the appearance of the holy Manifestations hath ever been the establishment of fellowship and love in the world of humanity."[9]

"Know thou of a certainty that Love is the secret of God's holy Dispensation, the manifestation of the All-Merciful, the fountain of spiritual outpourings. Love is heaven's kindly light, the Holy Spirit's eternal breath that vivifieth the human soul."[10]

And, in relation to truthfulness, we are advised:

"Say: Let truthfulness and courtesy be your adorning."[11]

"Without truthfulness progress and success, in all the worlds of God, are impossible for any soul."[12]

"Truthfulness is the goodliest of qualities as it comprehendeth all other virtues. A truthful person will be protected from all moral afflictions, will shrink from every evil deed, and be preserved from every wicked act, inasmuch as all vices and misdeeds are the very antithesis of truthfulness, and a truthful man will hold them all in utter abhorrence."[13]

Now, in addition to memorizing the quotations the children will learn by heart in these lessons, you may wish to commit to memory at least one passage from each set.

SECTION 4

With the above reflections in mind, reread the stories you will recount to your students in the first four lessons. As you will note, three of the four are drawn from the life of 'Abdu'l-Bahá, the embodiment of the highest human ideals. Some children you teach in Grade 1 may not yet be familiar with the personage of 'Abdu'l-Bahá, so you will need to briefly introduce Him to them. What you learned in the third unit of Book 2 has heightened your own awareness of His unique station, and as you advance in the study of the courses in this sequence you will grow in your gratitude to God for the precious gift He has bestowed upon humanity in the figure of 'Abdu'l-Bahá. What will you tell the children about Him as they start the first lesson in Grade 1?

From your study of the first unit, you know that, in relating the stories to the children, you will want to take them beyond the events and help them gain a glimpse of spiritual reality. You were already given an opportunity to think about how the story of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá’s guest in Lesson 1 will assist your students in understanding the significance of the quality of purity and what it means to strive for it. Let us examine the stories in the next three lessons in a similar way.

As you will have seen, in Lesson 2 you will narrate a story that illustrates ‘Abdu’l-Bahá’s concern for justice, which is the theme of the lesson. It describes an incident that occurs when ‘Abdu’l-Bahá travels one day from ‘Akká to Haifa. There are a few details the children will have to grasp if they are to follow the story—for example, the difference between a seat in a regular coach and one in a private carriage. This will help them see that ‘Abdu’l-Bahá was willing to give up His personal comfort in order to be able to give spiritual and material sustenance to those who were in need. How will you make sure it comes across to your students that ‘Abdu’l-Bahá’s way of life—of not spending on Himself unnecessarily and providing for those in need—manifested the spiritual quality of justice? What are some details that should be clear in your mind before you tell the story?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Love is the theme of Lesson 3, and here you will tell the children a story about a man in ‘Akká who, though always disrespectful to ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, was the recipient of His loving-kindness over many years. It is easy, of course, to have love in our hearts for those who are kind to us. But ‘Abdu’l-Bahá’s love knew no bounds and was not conditional. In the way you narrate the story, how will you make sure this characteristic of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá’s love becomes apparent to the children? How can you assist them in appreciating the power of love to transform the heart of someone who is behaving wrongly out of ignorance? What are some of the details that, if left out, would make it difficult for the children to follow the story and gain this insight?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Lesson 4, which is focused on the quality of truthfulness, includes the widely known story of the shepherd who cries wolf. The story demonstrates the consequences of the young shepherd’s lies, which the children will readily grasp. But you will want them to go further and recognize the reward of being truthful. What is this reward, and how will you make sure the children glean this from the story?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

SECTION 5

In these sections you have thought about the spiritual qualities addressed in the first four lessons of Grade 1, deepening your own understanding of their significance. You have seen, too, how the stories offer a glimpse into the nature of the qualities that you hope your students will develop further in this grade.

Before you move on to the next four lessons, you should spend some time with your fellow participants preparing to teach these first four. Drawing on the approaches discussed in the preceding unit, you can take turns with them introducing the prayer for memorization and presenting the spiritual quality discussed in each lesson, along with the quotation to be committed to memory. You should narrate the stories to one another and play the games and sing the songs together until you can teach them with a degree of confidence. Think about how you will introduce the coloring sheets. It may be helpful, before you begin this exercise, to review Sections 17 through 24 in the first unit. After practicing the various elements as suggested, each of the members of your group could be asked to teach one or more lessons while the others act as students. It may even be possible, depending on your circumstances, to gather three or four children together and go through the lessons with them.

In carrying out the above practice, you will probably want to take down notes about each lesson and record your thoughts on how to teach it. Further, for some of the games, you may need to prepare items in advance of the lesson. Many teachers dedicate a section of the notebook described in the first unit to such preparations.

Remember that, while you will surely carry this book and your notebook to class with you, you do not want to simply read from them. To the extent that you are able to present the content with ease and enthusiasm will your students be able to engage with the activities. Practice and preparation, then, will be essential.

SECTION 6

For Lessons 5 to 8, it is suggested that you recite the following prayer from memory to open each class period:

> **"O Thou kind Lord! These lovely children are the handiwork of the fingers of Thy might and the wondrous signs of Thy greatness. O God! Protect these children, graciously assist them to be educated and enable them to render service to the world of humanity. O God! These children are pearls, cause them to be nurtured within the shell of Thy loving-kindness.**
>
> **"Thou art the Bountiful, the All-Loving."[14]**

You may wish to take a moment to reflect on these words in light of your teaching efforts. How will they influence the way you approach each class period? How will they strengthen the love of God in the tender hearts of the children?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

In these lessons you will help your students commit the prayer below to memory, which, as you know, they will find easier to do if they have some understanding of its significance. You can write down in the space provided a few of your thoughts in this respect. What words do you think they might find new or unfamiliar, and how can you explain them through situations with which the children can easily identify? Besides such words, you may need to help them understand that both a lamp and a star give off light and that, without light, there is darkness, and we cannot see and can get lost. In the prayer, then, we ask God that we may shine forth with spiritual light, and we testify to His might and power to do as He wishes.

"O God, guide me, protect me, make of me a shining lamp and a brilliant star. Thou art the Mighty and the Powerful."[15]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

SECTION 7

Now read through Lessons 5 to 8, one by one, paying particular attention to the introductory ideas you will share with the students and the quotations they will commit to memory. Indicate here the spiritual quality discussed in each lesson:

Lesson 5: _____

Lesson 6: _____

Lesson 7: _____

Lesson 8: _____

Below are a few quotations from the Writings that offer insight into these four qualities. Reflect on each set as you did previously and write down some of your thoughts in the space provided.

On the quality of generosity, we read:

"Be generous in your days of plenty, and be patient in the hour of loss."[16]

"The beginning of magnanimity is when man expendeth his wealth on himself, on his family and on the poor among his brethren in his Faith."[17]

"The more antagonism they meet, the more let them show their own good faith; the more torments and calamities they have to face, the more generously let them pass round the bounteous cup. Such is the spirit which will become the life of the world, such is the spreading light at its heart . . ."[18]

"Be ye daysprings of generosity, dawning-points of the mysteries of existence, sites where inspiration alighteth, rising-places of splendors, souls that are sustained by the Holy Spirit, enamored of the Lord, detached from all save Him, holy above the characteristics of humankind, clothed in the attributes of the angels of heaven, that ye may win for yourselves the highest bestowal of all, in this new time, this wondrous age."[19]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Regarding selflessness, we are exhorted:

". . . you must have infinite love for each other, each preferring the other before himself."[20]

"Lord! Give me to drink from the chalice of selflessness; with its robe clothe me, and in its ocean immerse me. Make me as dust in the pathway of Thy loved ones, and grant that I may offer up my soul for the earth ennobled by the footsteps of Thy chosen ones in Thy path, O Lord of Glory in the Highest."[21]

"Man is he who forgets his own interests for the sake of others. His own comfort he forfeits for the well-being of all. Nay, rather, his own life must he be willing to forfeit for the life of mankind. Such a man is the honor of the world of humanity. Such a man is the glory of the world of mankind. Such a man is the one who wins eternal bliss. Such a man is near to the threshold of God. Such a man is the very manifestation of eternal happiness."[22]

_____

_____

In the following quotations, we catch a glimpse of the dynamics of joyfulness:

"Soar upon the wings of joy in the atmosphere of the love of God."[23]

"All joy to such as have attained His presence, gazed upon His beauty, hearkened unto His melodies, and been quickened by the Word that hath issued forth from His sacred and exalted, His glorious and resplendent lips!"[24]

"Joy gives us wings! In times of joy our strength is more vital, our intellect keener, and our understanding less clouded."[25]

"So far as ye are able, ignite a candle of love in every meeting, and with tenderness rejoice and cheer ye every heart."[26]

The passages below speak to us of sincerity:

"Say: The sincere soul longeth for nearness to God even as the suckling babe yearneth for its mother's breast, nay more ardent is his longing, could ye but know it! Again, his longing is even as the panting of one sore athirst after the living waters of grace, or the yearning of the sinner for forgiveness and mercy."[27]

"In these days truthfulness and sincerity are sorely afflicted in the clutches of falsehood, and justice is tormented by the scourge of injustice."[28]

"It behooveth everyone to traverse this brief span of life with sincerity and fairness."[29]

"Your hearts must be pure and your intentions sincere in order that you may become recipients of the divine bestowals."[30]

Try to memorize at least one passage from each of the sets above.

SECTION 8

Now let us turn to the stories in Lessons 5 to 8 and think about how they will help the children gain insight into the spiritual qualities they are exploring. After rereading each story, consider the questions below.

Generosity is the main theme of the story in Lesson 5, which describes an incident that occurred in ‘Abdu’l-Bahá’s childhood involving His Father’s flock of sheep. What parts of the story relate to the main theme? What are some of the details which, if left out, would make it difficult for the children to follow the story? Most important, of course, is the pleasure shown by Bahá’u’lláh upon learning of His Son’s spirit of generosity towards the shepherds. His remarks foretold how ‘Abdu’l-Bahá would grow up to give everything He had for the good of humanity, not only material possessions but His whole Being. How will you make sure the children recognize the extent of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá’s generosity, which was without limits?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

The story in Lesson 6 offers children a glimpse of the ways of selflessness. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, in declining to accept the expensive coat, showed how He preferred others to Himself. How will you ensure the children reach this conclusion from your narration? What are some of the details that should be clear in your mind before you tell the story?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

The theme of Lesson 7 is joyfulness, and you will relate a story about Leroy Ioas, who, as a young child, met ‘Abdu’l-Bahá and who went on to dedicate his life to the promotion of the Cause of God. In the story, Leroy decides not to give ‘Abdu’l-Bahá the bouquet of flowers he has bought for Him; he wants to offer Him his heart instead. For the children to understand why Leroy did this, it will be important for you to get across to them that the human heart is far more precious than anything material. Will it be enough for you to put emphasis in your voice when you tell that part of the story? What details will need to be emphasized in your narration, if the children are to follow the sequence of ideas and realize why ‘Abdu’l-Bahá’s gesture of presenting Leroy with the red rose from His coat gave the boy such joy?

Throughout His life, ‘Abdu’l-Bahá brought joy to everyone who came into His presence. In this account, we see that Leroy wanted nothing more than to gladden ‘Abdu’l-Bahá’s heart. Why is it imperative for children to understand that one of the greatest sources of joy is to bring joy to others?

Sincerity is the focus of Lesson 8, and in introducing the story to the children, you may wish to explain that, sometimes, we can better understand what it means to possess a quality by listening to an account that shows when it is lacking. The story of the man who convinces his neighbor to cut down his tree is an example. How will you help the children grasp what it means that appearances can sometimes be deceiving? In narrating the story, you will have to ensure the children do not go away thinking that the neighbor who was insincere actually was rewarded. What will you tell the children to help them understand the negative effects of insincerity?

SECTION 9

Now that you have gained some insight into the spiritual qualities discussed in Lessons 5 to 8, you should pause here to practice carrying out the lessons and their various elements with your fellow participants, as you did with the first four. Remember that, in your notebook, you can write down any points you want to keep about each lesson and record your thoughts on how to teach it.

SECTION 10

It is suggested that, for Lessons 9 to 12, you open each class period by saying the following prayer, which you are encouraged to commit to memory:

> **"O my Lord! Make Thy beauty to be my food, and Thy presence my drink, and Thy pleasure my hope, and praise of Thee my action, and remembrance of Thee my companion, and the power of Thy sovereignty my succorer, and Thy habitation my home, and my dwelling-place the seat Thou hast sanctified from the limitations imposed upon them who are shut out as by a veil from Thee.**
>
> **"Thou art, verily, the Almighty, the All-Glorious, the Most Powerful."[31]**

In these four lessons you will help your students memorize the prayer below. What words or phrases will you need to explain to the children for them to grasp the significance of the prayer?

"Blessed is the spot, and the house, and the place, and the city, and the heart, and the mountain, and the refuge, and the cave, and the valley, and the land, and the sea, and the island, and the meadow where mention of God hath been made, and His praise glorified."[32]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

SECTION 11

As you have done previously, read through Lessons 9 to 12, giving special attention to the introductory remarks and the quotations for memorization. Indicate below the spiritual quality on which each lesson is focused.

Lesson 9: _____

Lesson 10: _____

Lesson 11: _____

Lesson 12: _____

To deepen your own understanding of the significance of the above four qualities, reflect on the selection of quotations related to each one. As you do so, keep in mind the passage your students will be learning by heart. Afterwards write down your thoughts about the importance of the quality in the life of the individual and for a teacher of young children.

Regarding the quality of humility, the Writings tell us:

"Humility exalteth man to the heaven of glory and power, whilst pride abaseth him to the depths of wretchedness and degradation."[33]

"Every soul that walketh humbly with its God, in this Day, and cleaveth unto Him, shall find itself invested with the honor and glory of all goodly names and stations."[34]

"They who are the beloved of God, in whatever place they gather and whomsoever they may meet, must evince, in their attitude towards God, and in the manner of

their celebration of His praise and glory, such humility and submissiveness that every atom of the dust beneath their feet may attest the depth of their devotion."[35]

"It is certain that man's highest distinction is to be lowly before and obedient to his God . . ."[36]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

On the importance of thankfulness, we read:

"Know thou, that I have wafted unto thee all the fragrances of holiness, have fully revealed to thee My word, have perfected through thee My bounty and have desired for thee that which I have desired for My Self. Be then content with My pleasure and thankful unto Me."[37]

"Let God be all-sufficient for thee. Commune intimately with His Spirit, and be thou of the thankful."[38]

"Wherefore, be thankful to God, for having strengthened thee to aid His Cause, for having made the flowers of knowledge and understanding to spring forth in the garden of thine heart. Thus hath His grace encompassed thee, and encompassed the whole of creation."[39]

"The truth is that God has endowed man with virtues, powers and ideal faculties of which nature is entirely bereft and by which man is elevated, distinguished and superior. We must thank God for these bestowals, for these powers He has given us, for this crown He has placed upon our heads."[40]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

The quotations below speak to us of forgiveness:

"He should forgive the sinful, and never despise his low estate, for none knoweth what his own end shall be."[41]

"The inmost essence of all things voiceth in all things the testimony: 'All forgiveness floweth, in this Day, from God, Him to Whom none can compare, with Whom no partners can be joined, the Sovereign Protector of all men, and the Concealer of their sins!'"[42]

"Therefore, do not look at the shortcomings of anybody; see with the sight of forgiveness. The imperfect eye beholds imperfections. The eye that covers faults looks toward the Creator of souls."[43]

"Let not your heart be offended with anyone. If someone commits an error and wrong toward you, you must instantly forgive him."[44]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

And these extracts describe the standard of honesty to which we aspire:

"Say: Honesty, virtue, wisdom and a saintly character redound to the exaltation of man, while dishonesty, imposture, ignorance and hypocrisy lead to his abasement."[45]

"O ye friends of God in His cities and His loved ones in His lands! This Wronged One enjoineth on you honesty and piety. Blessed the city that shineth by their light. Through them man is exalted, and the door of security is unlocked before the face of all creation. Happy the man that cleaveth fast unto them, and recognizeth their virtue, and woe betide him that denieth their station."[46]

"Trustworthiness, wisdom and honesty are, of a truth, God's beauteous adornments for His creatures. These fair garments are a befitting vesture for every temple. Happy are those that comprehend, and well is it with them that acquire such virtues."[47]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Try to memorize at least one passage from each of the sets above.

SECTION 12

Now let us see how the stories in these four lessons will offer your students insight into the above spiritual qualities.

The story in Lesson 9 describes an incident that occurred when 'Abdu'l-Bahá met with some wealthy visitors; it will illustrate for the children His utter humility. That 'Abdu'l-Bahá

did not want to be treated with pomp and pageantry is a central idea. In what way does this demonstrate His humility? Of course, the particular form of pageantry—the bowl, the water, and the perfumed towel—is only an interesting detail and should not distract from the central theme in your telling of the story. Instead it is the conclusion that should be emphasized. How will it extend further the children's understanding of 'Abdu'l-Bahá's humility and His desire to serve others?

The theme of Lesson 10 is thankfulness, and the children will listen to a story about a lady who visits 'Abdu'l-Bahá and sets about sharing with Him all her troubles and woes. Later 'Abdu'l-Bahá introduces her to Mírzá Ḥaydar-'Alí, who, despite having experienced great difficulties in life, never ceases to be grateful for all the blessings he has received from God. In narrating the story, you will want it to become clear to your students that 'Abdu'l-Bahá did not introduce Mírzá Ḥaydar-'Alí to the lady by chance. What do you think the lady learned from her meeting with him? How does the story try to convey this lesson?

Forgiveness is the theme of Lesson 11, and you will tell your students a story about 'Abdu'l-Bahá that shows the effect of forgiveness on those we forgive. There are many details to the story that you will need to narrate clearly if the children are to follow the sequence of ideas. It involves a governor in 'Akká who sets out to do great harm to 'Abdu'l-Bahá and His companions in that city. In the story, not only does 'Abdu'l-Bahá forgive the governor for his actions; He treats the governor, who loses everything, with kindness and helps him in his hour of distress. What you should hope the children understand from the story is that forgiveness, as shown by 'Abdu'l-Bahá, goes beyond not harboring bad feelings towards those who wrong us. How will you know whether they have grasped this idea?

In the story for Lesson 12, the children will see how ‘Abdu’l-Bahá responds to a driver who demands an unfair price for a carriage ride. Although the essence of kindness and courtesy, ‘Abdu’l-Bahá never allowed people to act dishonestly or deceitfully towards Him or towards others. What do you think the driver learned from ‘Abdu’l-Bahá’s response? How will you help the children understand that what we really lose by being dishonest is far greater than anything material, like the handsome tip the driver lost?

SECTION 13

After you have practiced carrying out the activities in Lessons 9 to 12 with your fellow participants, you can move on to the next four. It is suggested that, for Lessons 13 to 16, you open each class period by reciting the following prayer from memory:

“O my merciful Lord! This is a hyacinth which hath grown in the garden of Thy good pleasure and a twig which hath appeared in the orchard of true knowledge. Cause it, O Lord of bounty, to be refreshed continually and at all times through Thy vitalizing breezes, and make it verdant, fresh and flourishing through the outpourings of the clouds of Thy favors, O Thou kind Lord!

“Verily Thou art the All-Glorious.”[48]

Below is the prayer your students will be learning to say by heart in Lessons 13 to 16. To help them gain an understanding of its significance, you should identify any words or phrases that will be new or unfamiliar to your students and devise appropriate sentences to explain them. Of course, they will easily grasp the imagery in the prayer, which will resonate with the one you will be reciting from memory in these lessons.

“O Lord! Plant this tender seedling in the garden of Thy manifold bounties, water it from the fountains of Thy loving-kindness and grant that it may grow into a goodly plant through the outpourings of Thy favor and grace.

“Thou art the Mighty and the Powerful.”[49]

SECTION 14

Write down the qualities addressed in Lessons 13 to 16, after you have read through each one in the usual way with your fellow participants.

Lesson 13: _____

Lesson 14: _____

Lesson 15: _____

Lesson 16: _____

The following quotations will provide you with the opportunity to reflect further on the spiritual qualities discussed in these lessons, as you have done previously.

On the importance of showing forth compassion, we read:

"Radiate the lights of compassion so that the hearts may be cleansed and purified and that they may take a share and portion from Thy confirmations."[50]

"Be compassionate, so that your actions will shine like unto the light streaming forth from the lamp."[51]

"Ye are the fruits of one tree and the leaves of one branch; be ye compassionate and kind to all the human race."[52]

"Now must the lovers of God arise to carry out these instructions of His: let them be kindly fathers to the children of the human race, and compassionate brothers to the youth, and self-denying offspring to those bent with years."[53]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

About the quality of detachment, we are advised:

"Detach yourselves from all else but Me, and turn your faces towards My face, for better is this for you than the things ye possess."[54]

"Delight not yourselves in the things of the world and its vain ornaments, neither set your hopes on them. Let your reliance be on the remembrance of God, the Most Exalted, the Most Great."[55]

"The essence of detachment is for man to turn his face towards the courts of the Lord, to enter His Presence, behold His Countenance, and stand as witness before Him."[56]

"Detachment is as the sun; in whatsoever heart it doth shine it quencheth the fire of covetousness and self. He whose sight is illumined with the light of understanding will assuredly detach himself from the world and the vanities thereof. . . . Let not the world and its vileness grieve you. Happy is he whom riches fill not with vain-glory, nor poverty with sorrow."[57]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

The following passages speak to us about the quality of contentment:

"O Son of Man! Wert thou to speed through the immensity of space and traverse the expanse of heaven, yet thou wouldst find no rest save in submission to Our command and humbleness before Our Face."[58]

"O quintessence of passion! Put away all covetousness and seek contentment; for the covetous hath ever been deprived, and the contented hath ever been loved and praised."[59]

"Tread, therefore, the path of acquiescence and resignation. Let no hardship sadden thy heart, nor set thy hope upon any worldly gifts. Be happy and content with whatsoever God hath willed, that thy heart and soul may find tranquility and thine inner being and conscience may experience true joy."[60]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

The extracts below illumine our understanding of kindness:

"We love to see you at all times consorting in amity and concord within the paradise of My good-pleasure, and to inhale from your acts the fragrance of friendliness and unity, of loving-kindness and fellowship."[61]

"Be ye sincerely kind, not in appearance only. Let each one of God's loved ones center his attention on this: to be the Lord's mercy to man; to be the Lord's

grace. Let him do some good to every person whose path he crosseth, and be of some benefit to him."[62]

". . . why should men be unjust and unkind to each other, showing forth that which is contrary to God? As He loves us, why should we entertain animosity and hate? If God did not love all, He would not have created, trained and provided for all. Loving-kindness is the divine policy."[63]

"Do not be content with showing friendship in words alone, let your heart burn with loving kindness for all who may cross your path."[64]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Try to memorize at least one passage from each of the sets above.

SECTION 15

Having deepened your understanding of the spiritual qualities addressed in Lessons 13 to 16, reread the four stories and discuss the questions below with your group.

The theme of Lesson 13 is compassion, and the story you will narrate involves a woman who was turned away from the home where 'Abdu'l-Bahá was staying when she knocked on the door, hoping to meet Him. What part of the story illustrates His compassion towards the woman? What details will help the children follow the story and understand that a compassionate heart, while concerned for all equally, is especially sensitive to those who are in hardship, distress, or grief?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Lesson 14 is focused on the spiritual quality of detachment. The story involves two friends who decide to go on a journey to the Holy Land, one who is wealthy and the other who is less so. Of course, to gain insight into the quality of detachment, the children will need to recognize that the journey to the Holy Land is symbolic of drawing closer to God. What you will want the children to understand is that detachment is not dependent on how much or how little we possess, but on whether we allow our possessions to keep us from drawing near to God. How will the story help foster this understanding?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

The story in Lesson 15 will provide the children with insight into the quality of contentment, which is the main theme. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá tells His companions that He was happy while imprisoned in the fortress-city of ‘Akká because He passed those days in the path of service. How will this statement affect the children’s understanding of contentment? How will they see that, though physically imprisoned, ‘Abdu’l-Bahá’s spirit could never be confined?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

In relating the story in Lesson 16, which involves a man in ‘Akká who was consumed by anger and hatred, you will need to emphasize certain details; otherwise the children could miss how it relates to the main theme of kindness. What are these details? What lesson does ‘Abdu’l-Bahá teach the man who clung to his anger and hatred for so long?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

SECTION 16

It is hoped that your analysis of Lessons 13 to 16 was fruitful and that you and your fellow participants enjoyed practicing the various elements together. As for Lessons 17 to 20, you could recite the following prayer from memory at the start of every class period:

> **“O my God! O my God! This, Thy servant, hath advanced towards Thee, is passionately wandering in the desert of Thy love, walking in the path of Thy service, anticipating Thy favors, hoping for Thy bounty, relying upon Thy kingdom, and intoxicated by the wine of Thy gift. O my God! Increase the fervor of his affection for Thee, the constancy of his praise of Thee, and the ardor of his love for Thee.**

"Verily, Thou art the Most Generous, the Lord of grace abounding. There is no other God but Thee, the Forgiving, the Merciful."[65]

In these lessons, the children will focus on learning to recite the prayer below by heart, and you should note down, as you have with the others, how you will make sure they gain some understanding of the words they are committing to memory. This prayer is somewhat lengthier than previous ones, and if the children find it, or any others, challenging to memorize in the allotted four lessons, you should make whatever adjustments you think necessary.

"Thy name is my healing, O my God, and remembrance of Thee is my remedy. Nearness to Thee is my hope, and love for Thee is my companion. Thy mercy to me is my healing and my succor in both this world and the world to come. Thou, verily, art the All-Bountiful, the All-Knowing, the All-Wise."[66]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

SECTION 17

To begin your review of Lessons 17 to 20, read through them one at a time in the usual way, and write down the spiritual qualities that you will be exploring in them with the children.

Lesson 17: _____

Lesson 18: _____

Lesson 19: _____

Lesson 20: _____

Below are a few quotations that will help you and your fellow participants gain insights into the significance of the above qualities. Remember to discuss them not only from the perspective of the life of the individual; you should also think about what they mean for a teacher of young children such as yourself.

On the quality of courage, we are exhorted:

"Strive as much as ye can to turn wholly toward the Kingdom, that ye may acquire innate courage and ideal power."[67]

"May you be sources of comfort to the broken in heart. May you be a refuge for the wanderer. May you be a source of courage to the affrighted one. Thus, through the favor and assistance of God may the standard of the happiness of humanity be held aloft in the center of the world and the ensign of universal agreement be unfurled."[68]

Concerning the importance of hopefulness, we read:

"Set all thy hope in God, and cleave tenaciously to His unfailing mercy. Who else but Him can enrich the destitute, and deliver the fallen from his abasement?"[69]

"O Moving Form of Dust! I desire communion with thee, but thou wouldst put no trust in Me. The sword of thy rebellion hath felled the tree of thy hope. At all times I am near unto thee, but thou art ever far from Me. Imperishable glory I have chosen for thee, yet boundless shame thou hast chosen for thyself. While there is yet time, return, and lose not thy chance."[70]

"Man is under all conditions immersed in a sea of God's blessings. Therefore, be thou not hopeless under any circumstances, but rather be firm in thy hope."[71]

"If the heart turns away from the blessings God offers how can it hope for happiness? If it does not put its hope and trust in God's Mercy, where can it find rest? Oh, trust in God! for His Bounty is everlasting, and in His Blessings, for they are superb."[72]

And regarding trustworthiness, the Writings tell us:

"O people! The goodliest vesture in the sight of God in this day is trustworthiness. All bounty and honor shall be the portion of the soul that arrayeth itself with this greatest of adornments."[73]

"Trustworthiness is as a stronghold to the city of humanity, and as eyes to the human temple. Whosoever remaineth deprived thereof shall, before His Throne, be reckoned as one bereft of vision."[74]

"Be ye God's manifestations of trustworthiness in every land. So perfectly should ye mirror forth this quality that even were ye to travel through cities heaped with gold, your gaze would not for a single moment be seduced by its allure."[75]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

And these words speak to us of enkindlement:

"O Friends! You must all be so ablaze in this day with the fire of the love of God that the heat thereof may be manifest in all your veins, your limbs and members of your body, and the peoples of the world may be ignited by this heat and turn to the horizon of the Beloved."[76]

"Let thy soul glow with the flame of this undying Fire that burneth in the midmost heart of the world, in such wise that the waters of the universe shall be powerless to cool down its ardor."[77]

"Burn thou brightly with the flame of this undying Fire which the All-Merciful hath ignited in the midmost heart of creation, that through thee the heat of His love may be kindled within the hearts of His favored ones. Follow in My way and enrapture the hearts of men through remembrance of Me, the Almighty, the Most Exalted."[78]

"Kindle the fire of love and burn away all things; then set thy foot into the land of the lovers."[79]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Try to memorize at least one passage from each of the sets above.

SECTION 18

Now let us turn to the stories in Lessons 17 to 20. After rereading each one, consider the questions below with the other members of your group.

In Lesson 17 you will tell the story of 'Alí-'Askar, who, even when threatened by a corrupt official, could not be persuaded to lie and cheat. The children already know well that

lying is not pleasing in the sight of God. The story will enable them to see how obedience to the teachings of God is a source of courage, which is the theme of the lesson. What parts of the story will help them make this connection? What details will be important for you to emphasize in narrating the events if the children are to follow the story and understand this important point?

Lesson 18 revolves around the quality of hopefulness, and you will tell the children a story of a downhearted man whose hope is restored by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá. He showers the man with kindness and reminds him that he is rich in the Kingdom of God. To be rich in the Kingdom of God does not mean that we have great material wealth. What does it mean? How does ‘Abdu’l-Bahá’s reminder increase the man’s trust in God’s bounties? How will you assist the children in recognizing that, without trust in God, it is difficult to remain hopeful?

Trustworthiness is the theme of Lesson 19, and to illustrate the importance of this quality you will tell your students the story of Muḥammad-Taqí, who was trusted by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá with the task of receiving and dispatching mail in the Holy Land. There are many details you will need to keep in mind when narrating the story so that the children do not miss its main idea. What are they? In describing Muḥammad-Taqí, you will use the words “reliable” and “dependable”. Do you think it is possible to be careless and trustworthy at the same time?

The figure of Thomas Breakwell is at the center of the story in Lesson 20, which is concerned with enkindlement. The metaphor of a lighted candle, a glowing flame, a blazing fire is often used in the Writings to help us understand the quality of enkindlement—the intensity of the love we have in our hearts for God. You should have confidence that, through this metaphor, your students will get some sense of what enkindlement means. The ability for abstract thinking exists in children from a young age, and it develops as their facility

with language grows. With these thoughts in mind, identify which parts of the story show how Thomas Breakwell was enkindled with the fire of the love of God. What are some of the details that make the story engaging?

SECTION 19

It is assumed that you and your fellow participants drew inspiration from practicing the elements of Lessons 17 to 20 and that you are now ready to move on to the final four in Grade 1, Lessons 21 to 24. You may wish to recite this prayer from memory at the start of every class period:

> **"Create in me a pure heart, O my God, and renew a tranquil conscience within me, O my Hope! Through the spirit of power confirm Thou me in Thy Cause, O my Best-Beloved, and by the light of Thy glory reveal unto me Thy path, O Thou the Goal of my desire! Through the power of Thy transcendent might lift me up unto the heaven of Thy holiness, O Source of my being, and by the breezes of Thine eternity gladden me, O Thou Who art my God! Let Thine everlasting melodies breathe tranquility on me, O my Companion, and let the riches of Thine ancient countenance deliver me from all except Thee, O my Master, and let the tidings of the revelation of Thine incorruptible Essence bring me joy, O Thou Who art the most manifest of the manifest and the most hidden of the hidden!"[80]**

Below is the final prayer the children will memorize in this grade. Though they will readily understand much of its significance, you should decide how you will explain any words or phrases they may find new or unfamiliar.

> **"O Thou kind Lord! I am a little child, exalt me by admitting me to the kingdom. I am earthly, make me heavenly; I am of the world below, let me belong to the realm above; gloomy, suffer me to become radiant; material, make me spiritual, and grant that I may manifest Thine infinite bounties.**
>
> **"Thou art the Powerful, the All-Loving."[81]**

SECTION 20

Read the final four lessons you will be teaching in Grade 1, paying particular attention, as always, to the ideas you will share with your students to introduce the quotations they will learn by heart. Write down the quality on which each lesson focuses.

Lesson 21: _____

Lesson 22: _____

Lesson 23: _____

Lesson 24: _____

The following quotations will provide you and the other members of your group with the opportunity to reflect together on the spiritual qualities addressed in these lessons, as you have done for the previous ones.

On the significance of radiance, the Writings tell us:

"O flame of the love of God! The ray must shed light and the sun must rise; the full moon must shine and the star must gleam. Since thou art a ray, beseech thou the Lord to enable thee to give illumination and enlightenment, to brighten the horizons and to consume the world with the fire of the love of God."[82]

"Live ye one with another, O people, in radiance and joy."[83]

"The All-Loving God created man to radiate the Divine light and to illumine the world by his words, action and life."[84]

"Service to humanity is service to God. Let the love and light of the Kingdom radiate through you until all who look upon you shall be illumined by its reflection. Be as stars, brilliant and sparkling in the loftiness of their heavenly station."[85]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

From these passages, we gain insight into the quality of faithfulness:

"The glory of God rest upon thee, upon every steadfast and unwavering heart and upon every constant and faithful soul."[86]

"Convey thou unto the handmaids of the Merciful the message that when a test turneth violent they must stand unmoved, and faithful to their love for Bahá. In

winter come the storms, and the great winds blow, but then will follow spring in all its beauty, adorning hill and plain with perfumed plants and red anemones, fair to see."[87]

"In this day, the one favored at the Threshold of the Lord is he who handeth round the cup of faithfulness; who bestoweth, even upon his enemies, the jewel of bounty, and lendeth, even to his fallen oppressor, a helping hand; it is he who will, even to the fiercest of his foes, be a loving friend."[88]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

The passages below tell us about patience:

"O Son of Man! For everything there is a sign. The sign of love is fortitude under My decree and patience under My trials."[89]

"Blessed are the steadfastly enduring, they that are patient under ills and hardships, who lament not over anything that befalleth them, and who tread the path of resignation."[90]

"Be content with that which hath been ordained by an irrevocable decree, and be of them that endure with patience."[91]

"It behooveth whosoever hath set his face towards the Most Sublime Horizon to cleave tenaciously unto the cord of patience, and to put his reliance in God, the Help in Peril, the Unconstrained."[92]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

And we read the following in relation to steadfastness:

"The first and foremost duty prescribed unto men, next to the recognition of Him Who is the Eternal Truth, is the duty of steadfastness in His Cause."[93]

"Such must be thy steadfastness in the Cause of God, that no earthly thing whatsoever will have the power to deter thee from thy duty."[94]

"Walk thou steadfastly in the love of God, and keep straight on in His Faith, and aid Him through the power of thine utterance."[95]

"Thus with steadfast steps we may tread the Path of certitude, that perchance the breeze that bloweth from the meads of the good-pleasure of God may waft upon us the sweet savors of divine acceptance, and cause us, vanishing mortals that we are, to attain unto the Kingdom of everlasting glory."[96]

"Be ye confident and steadfast; your services are confirmed by the powers of heaven, for your intentions are lofty, your purposes pure and worthy."[97]

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Try to memorize at least one passage from each of the sets above.

SECTION 21

Now let us look at the last four stories you will narrate to your students, with whom you will have spent so many wonderful hours together, striving to nurture in them the spiritual qualities they have been learning about. After rereading each story, discuss the questions below with your group.

In Lesson 21, the children will listen to a story about Dorothy Baker as a young girl, when she met 'Abdu'l-Bahá for the first time. They will see how, in the course of the story, she becomes enamored of His radiance, which is the main theme. What effect does 'Abdu'l-Bahá's radiance have on Dorothy? How do you hope the story will increase the children's attachment to 'Abdu'l-Bahá?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

The theme of Lesson 22 is faithfulness, a quality illustrated by the story of Isfandíyár. What parts of the story are most directly related to this theme? What other spiritual qualities does Isfandíyár demonstrate that help him to remain faithful? What details will you be sure to include in your narration?

_____

_____

_____

Lesson 23 focuses on the quality of patience. In the story, Li Xin shows patience while he tends to his peach tree as it passes through various stages of growth—from a small seed into a tree that finally bears fruit. The story emphasizes the joy rewarded by patience exercised over a long period of exertion and demonstrates how often, before seeing the fruits of our labors, we must exert a great deal of effort. Why is it important for children to view the spiritual quality of patience in this way? What details will you want to have clear in your mind when narrating the story to your students?

In Lesson 24 you will tell the children a story about the life of Bahíyyih Khánum, the sister of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá. It will demonstrate to them how Bahíyyih Khánum manifested steadfastness in the face of adversity. But you will also want them to take away the understanding that steadfastness in the love of God involves more than overcoming any one specific crisis or difficulty. How will the story of her life give the children a glimpse of the strength and constancy that firmness in the Cause of God demands?

SECTION 22

In this unit, you have thought about the spiritual qualities you will be exploring with children in the first grade and have practiced carrying out the various elements of the twenty-four lessons you will be teaching to them in the hope of contributing to the development of their character. Take a moment now to call to your mind all the spiritual qualities you will have the bounty of helping your students develop in Grade 1. It seems fitting that, from among these, steadfastness in the love of God is the theme with which they will conclude their lessons, just as it will be important for them to begin, as discussed earlier, by focusing on purity of heart. As you embark on your first teaching effort, you should reflect often on how steadfastness in His love will help the students in your care persevere in their efforts to manifest all the gemlike qualities latent within them.